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Open Translator's Notes (SIL)

2 John 1:1

Section 1–3: Greetings

Read 1–3 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: This is the introduction to the letter. In verse 1 the writer says who he is and who he is writing to. In verse 3 he gives a greeting in the form of a blessing. These three elements were the formal parts of the introduction to most Greek letters written at that time. In these verses John also introduces the ideas of love and God's truth, which are the main things he wants to remind his readers of in this letter.

1a

The elder,

- ¶ I, the church leader/elder, am writing this letter

1a–b

The elder, To: *(Discourse Feature)* This is the typical form of a Greek letter of John's time. However in many languages the writer of a letter introduces himself in the first person singular. For example, "I, the elder, am writing to…." In translation the natural form for starting a letter should be used.

elder: *(Meaning)* Although John was an old man when he wrote this letter, he is probably using the term *elder* here with the meaning "church leader" or "senior Christian," as in Acts 14:23 and Titus 1:5–6.

1b

To the chosen lady and her children,

- to you, the lady whom God has chosen to be among his people, and to your children.

chosen: *(Passive Construction)* It may be necessary to make explicit that it is God who has chosen the "lady" to be among his people.

lady and her children: *(Discourse Feature)* John is using these terms to refer to a local church and its members. However, this is not a Greek figure of speech. John here uses these terms as a kind of secret code, probably to avoid mentioning names and putting Christians in danger of persecution. Therefore these terms should be kept in your translation and not changed to "church" and "Christians," since that would be hiding the fact that John was writing in code here.

1c

whom I love in the truth—

- I love you all truly,

whom I love: *(Pronoun Reference)* John means that he loves both the lady and her children.

in the truth: *(Alternative Interpretations)* There are two different interpretations of what the Greek phrase means here:

1. It probably means "truly/really." (GNT, NEB, LB, JBP)
2. It may mean "because we all believe in God's truth."

1d

and not I alone,

- and it is not only I who truly love you all,

1e

but also all who know the truth—

- for everyone else who knows the true things which God has revealed also loves you truly.

1d–e

not I alone, but also: *(Ellipsis)* This is a short way of saying "I am not the only one who truly loves you. All who know the truth also love you truly."

2 John 1:2

Section 1–3: Greetings

Read 1–3 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: This is the introduction to the letter. In verse 1 the writer says who he is and who he is writing to. In verse 3 he gives a greeting in the form of a blessing. These three elements were the formal parts of the introduction to most Greek letters written at that time. In these verses John also introduces the ideas of love and God's truth, which are the main things he wants to remind his readers of in this letter.

2a

because of the truth that abides in us

- I love you(plur) because we(incl) know the true things which God has revealed,

the truth that abides in us: *(Meaning)* John means that he loves the people he is writing to because both he and they know and believe the truth that God has taught them.

2b

and will be with us forever:

- and we will always know them.

will be with us: *(Collocation)* In some languages it may not be natural to talk about an abstract thing like "truth" being with a person. The meaning here is that we will never stop knowing God's truth.

2 John 1:3

Section 1–3: Greetings

Read 1–3 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: This is the introduction to the letter. In verse 1 the writer says who he is and who he is writing to. In verse 3 he gives a greeting in the form of a blessing. These three elements were the formal parts of the introduction to most Greek letters written at that time. In these verses John also introduces the ideas of love and God's truth, which are the main things he wants to remind his readers of in this letter.

3a

Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and from Jesus Christ, the Son of the Father, will be with us

- May God, our Father, and Jesus Christ, his Son, bless us(incl) and be merciful/kind to us, and cause us to live in peace/quietness.

Grace, mercy, and peace: *(Discourse Feature)* This seems to have been a standard Christian greeting, since something like it appears in most of the New Testament letters. In translation it should sound like a greeting. It should not be in focus as if it were a teaching or a prayer that John made up.

the Son of the Father: *(Translation)* In your language it may be necessary to state this in full, "the son of God our father."

will be with us: *(Alternative Interpretations)* There are two different views about the grammar of the Greek verb here:

3. It probably signifies a greeting in the form of a wish, "May grace, mercy and peace…be with us." (GNT, JBP, KJV)
4. It may be signifying a statement. For example, *Grace, mercy and peace…will be with us.* (BSB, JB, NEB, RSV, LB)

3b

in truth

- May they do these things for us(incl) as we live according to the true things that God has revealed

3c

and love.

- and as we love one another.

3b–c

in truth and love: *(Meaning)* Here John repeats his theme of truth and love. He means that we may experience God's grace, mercy and peace as we put into practice the truth we have learned from him and as we love one another. See JB.

2 John 1:4

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 4–6

Read 4–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John expresses his approval of his readers' Christian lives and urges them to obey God's commands, especially the command to love one another.

4a

I was overjoyed

- ¶ I was very happy

4b

to find some of your children

- when/because I heard about some of your children,

to find: *(Alternative Interpretations)* There are different views about which sense the Greek verb is being used in here:

5. It is probably being used in the sense of finding out or hearing that something is true.
6. Some think it is used in the sense of meeting someone or discovering something.

some of your children: *(Meaning)* John is not contrasting some who are living by the truth and some who are not. He is saying that he has only heard about some of them and this is what he has heard.

your children: *(Discourse Feature)* The same term should be used here as in verse 1.

4c

walking in the truth,

- that they are living in God's true way.
- that they are doing what God has shown us(incl) he truly wants us to do.

walking in the truth: *(Metaphor)* This is a Greek metaphor meaning, "putting into practice in their lives the truth which God has revealed about how he wants them to live."

4d

just as the Father has commanded us.

- They are doing just what God our Father told us(incl) we should do.

2 John 1:5

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 4–6

Read 4–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John expresses his approval of his readers' Christian lives and urges them to obey God's commands, especially the command to love one another.

5

And now I urge you, dear lady—not as a new commandment to you, but one we have had from the beginning—that we love one another.

- So, sister/lady, I say to you that we(incl) Christians should be loving one another. This is not a command which you(plur) have never heard about before. It is a command which we(incl) have known since the time when we began to follow Christ.

dear lady: *(Translation)* In your translation the appropriate term should be used here. John is a respected elder addressing a respected lady. See note on 1b.

not…a new commandment: *(Focus)* John is referring to a command from God, not from himself. As in 1 John 2:7, he is saying that when Christians are living as God wants them to live they must be always loving one another. He reminds his readers that this command is not new, because Jesus had given it to his disciples many years before (John 13:34).

from the beginning: *(Meaning)* As in 1 John 2:7, this refers to the time when they first became Christians.

that we love one another: *(Focus)* This is John's main point in this verse. To make the emphasis clear you may need to put it at the beginning of the verse, as in GNT, or make it an independent sentence as in NIV.

2 John 1:6

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 4–6

Read 4–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John expresses his approval of his readers' Christian lives and urges them to obey God's commands, especially the command to love one another.

6a

And this is love, that we walk according to His commandments.

- Real love is what we(incl) do when we obey God's commands.
- The true way to love God is to live as God has said we(incl) should live.

this is love: *(Lexical Problem)* In some languages it may not be possible to talk about love without indicating the object of the love. If that is the case in your language you may have to refer to "the true way for someone to love God." This is different from the translation of the same phrase in 1 John 4:10, because John's focus is different in this passage.

this: *(Pronoun Reference)* The word *this* refers forward to the idea of obeying God's commands. John is saying that obeying God's commands is the real sign of our love for God.

we walk according to: *(Metaphor)* This is a similar metaphor to "walking in the truth" in verse 4. The phrase "we walk according to" means that in our daily lives we obey his commands.

His commandments: *(Pronoun Reference)* This refers to God's commands. It may need to be made explicit in your translation. See GNT, NEB.

6b

This is the very commandment you have heard from the beginning,

- Since the time when you(plur) began to follow Christ

6c

that you must walk in love.

- you have heard that God has commanded that you should be always loving one another.

walk in love: *(Metaphor)* This is a similar metaphor to "walk in obedience." It means that it should be obvious in our lives that we love one another.

2 John 1:7

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 7–11

Read 7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John explains the problem which caused him to write this letter. There are false teachers traveling around. If the church welcomes them, they will lead the church into sin. So John shows his readers how to recognize them from their teaching and he warns his readers to have nothing to do with such people.

7a

For many deceivers have gone out into the world, refusing to confess the coming of Jesus Christ in the flesh.

- ¶ I say this because everywhere there are many people who deceive others by teaching things that are not true. They say that Jesus Christ did not come to this world as a human being.

For: *(Logical Relationship)* Although many English versions do not translate the Greek connecting word here, it may be good in your translation to follow the example of the BSB and translate it in order to show that John is now going to explain why he said what he said in verses 4–6.

deceivers: *(Meaning)* This term means people who claimed to be giving Christian teaching, but in fact they were deceiving those who they taught, because their teaching was not true Christianity.

have gone out into the world: *(Multiple Senses)* As in 1 John 4:1, this phrase is not being used in the sense of leaving a specific place; rather it refers to many people going to different places.

refusing to confess the coming of Jesus Christ in the flesh: *(Meaning)* This is referring to the same false teaching as 1 John 4:2. See the notes on that verse. These people denied that Jesus Christ became a real human being when he came into the world.

7b

Any such person is the deceiver and the antichrist.

- If any person says that, he is that well-known enemy of Christ, who is always deceiving people.

the deceiver and the antichrist: *(Meaning)* This is not referring to two separate people. It means "the antichrist, who is the main person who deceives people."

the antichrist: *(Biblical Term)* See antichrist in *Key Biblical Terms*.

2 John 1:8

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 7–11

Read 7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John explains the problem which caused him to write this letter. There are false teachers traveling around. If the church welcomes them, they will lead the church into sin. So John shows his readers how to recognize them from their teaching and he warns his readers to have nothing to do with such people.

8b

so that you do not lose what we have worked for,

- so that your efforts to serve God are not wasted,

8a-b

Watch yourselves, so that you do not…: *(Logical Connection)* John is telling his readers to watch out for these people so that they are not deceived by them. He warns the readers that if they are deceived they may not get the rewards which God wants to give them.

8a

Watch yourselves,

- Therefore you(plur) should take care that these people do not deceive you,

(GNT:) then: *(Logical Connection)* It may be helpful in translation to include a connecting word here to show that this warning is based on what is said in verse 7.

8c

but that you may be fully rewarded.

- and so that God will reward you fully for your service.
- and so that you will get all the blessing which God has promised to you.

8b-c

(NIV:) you…you…you: (Text) Some Greek manuscripts have "we" instead of "you" for some or all of the three verbs the NIV translates here as "lose," "work for" and "be rewarded." Different English versions follow different manuscripts, but the best text here is that followed by NIV.

(NIV:) do not lose what you have worked for: *(Meaning)* This is a negative way of saying "you may be rewarded fully." It is referring to the idea that God will reward his people in heaven for their efforts to serve him in this world.

2 John 1:9

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 7–11

Read 7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John explains the problem which caused him to write this letter. There are false teachers traveling around. If the church welcomes them, they will lead the church into sin. So John shows his readers how to recognize them from their teaching and he warns his readers to have nothing to do with such people.

9a

Anyone who runs ahead

- I tell you(plur) that if anyone adds his own ideas to the things which Christ taught,

Anyone who runs ahead: *(Metaphor)* The topic of this metaphor is anyone who is not content with the teaching of Christ and therefore adds his own teaching to it. When someone does this he will begin to ignore the teaching of Christ.

9b

without remaining in the teaching of Christ

- and if he does not continue to believe in what Christ taught,

the teaching of Christ: *(Alternative Interpretations)* There are two ways of interpreting this "of" phrase:

7. It probably means "the things that Christ taught."
8. It may mean "the things we have been taught about Christ."

9c

does not have God.

- then he is not united with God.

have God: *(Meaning)* As in 1 John 2:23b this refers to a Christian's close relationship and union with God. Its meaning is similar to the phrase, "in God." See the note on 1 John 2:5c "in Him."

9d

Whoever remains in His teaching

- But if anyone keeps on believing in what Christ taught,

9e

has both the Father and the Son.

- he is united with God our Father and with Jesus Christ, God's Son.

the Father and the Son: *(Translation)* In your translation it may be necessary to expand this phrase to make it clear that it is referring to God the Father and God's Son. See the Display.

2 John 1:10

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 7–11

Read 7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John explains the problem which caused him to write this letter. There are false teachers traveling around. If the church welcomes them, they will lead the church into sin. So John shows his readers how to recognize them from their teaching and he warns his readers to have nothing to do with such people.

10a

If anyone comes to you

- And so, if anyone comes to you(plur) claiming to be teaching what he has received from God,

(TEV:) then: *(Logical Relationship)* It may be helpful in translation to have a connecting word at the beginning of verse 10. This could help to show that the instructions in verses 10 and 11 are based on what John has said in verses 7–9.

If anyone comes to you: *(Meaning)* John is referring to the false teachers who were traveling around from church to church.

to you: *(Pronoun Reference)* The *you* here is plural, referring to the lady and her children, or in other words, to all the Christians who John was writing to.

10b

but does not bring this teaching,

- and if he is teaching something which is different from what Christ taught,

this teaching: *(Pronoun Reference)* The phrase *this teaching* refers back to Christ's teachings as mentioned in verse 9.

10c

do not receive him into your home

- do not invite him to be a guest in your home.

do not receive him into your home: *(Meaning)* John means that the Christians should not entertain these false teachers as guests in their homes or invite them to stay with them.

10d

or even greet him.

- Do not even greet him as a fellow Christian.

or even greet him: *(Meaning)* This probably refers to greeting such a person as a fellow Christian.

2 John 1:11

Section 4–11: Obey God's commands and reject false teaching

Read 4–11 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main purpose of the letter. John reminds his readers of the importance of obeying God's commands. He therefore warns them not to have anything to do with false teachers who reject the truth about Christ.

Paragraph 7–11

Read 7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John explains the problem which caused him to write this letter. There are false teachers traveling around. If the church welcomes them, they will lead the church into sin. So John shows his readers how to recognize them from their teaching and he warns his readers to have nothing to do with such people.

11a

Whoever greets such a person

- I say this because if anyone greets such a person as a fellow Christian

(GNT:) For: *(Logical Relationship)* The connecting word shows that this verse gives the reason for the instruction not to welcome the false teachers.

11b

shares in his evil deeds.

- he is joining with that false teacher and taking part in the evil which he is doing.

shares in: *(Meaning)* This indicates that a person who welcomes a false teacher is helping him, and so he is becoming a partner with the false teacher in his evil deeds.

2 John 1:12

Section 12–13: Final comments

Read 12–13 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses contain John's final comments and greetings to close the letter.

12a

I have many things to write to you,

- ¶ There are many more things that I would like to tell you,(plur)

12b

but I would prefer not to do so with paper and ink.

- but I do not want to write them in a letter like this.

I would prefer not to do so with paper and ink: *(Meaning)* John is not saying that there is anything wrong with using paper and ink. This is merely another way of saying that he would prefer to talk with them face to face.

paper and ink: *(Translation)* This is an idiom meaning "in a letter." In your translation you should consider what is the natural way of saying this in your language.

12c

Instead, I hope to come and

- What I want and expect is that I will come and visit you,(plur)

12d

speak with you face to face,

- so that we(incl) can be together and talk together,

face to face: *(Translation)* This is also an idiom. It should be translated by a natural phrase for having a friendly personal talk with someone.

12e

so that our joy may be complete.

- and then we will rejoice together very much.
- and then we will be completely happy.

complete: *(Meaning)* As in 1 John 1:4, this means "as great as it can be," "without any sadness or anything to spoil it."

2 John 1:13

Section 12–13: Final comments

Read 12–13 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses contain John's final comments and greetings to close the letter.

13a

The children of your elect sister

- The children of your(sing) sister here, whom God has also chosen to be among his people,

children…sister: *(Discourse Feature)* John is using these terms in the same way that he used "lady" and "children" in verse 1. See the note on verse 1. Here these terms refer to the church and its members in the place where John was.

elect: *(Passive Construction)* As in verse 1, this is referring to the fact that God has chosen this "sister" to be among his people.

13b

send you greetings.

- they are greeting you.(sing)